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FIRESTORM The Godhra train blaze that set off the Gujarat riots

REUTERS

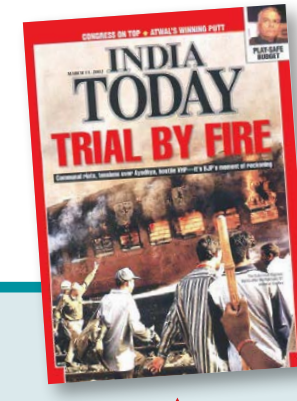


THE VICTIM

Just before this millennium began, in those heady days when devices and ideas were being advertised into the home of every Indian with a conviction that no sickness is immune to the loving touch of foreign capital, India's internal security problems marred an otherwise optimistic time.

Its seeds had been sown in the last season of frenzy. Right after watching the Babri Masjid domes come down on live TV, the nation had begun a long vigil as senseless violence rattled urban centres—months of rioting in Bombay had climaxed with 12 blasts in early 1993. Then had come a lull. That was broken in Delhi, in 1996, as a blast tore through Lajpat Nagar, claiming 13 lives, and mourned on the nightly news shoulder-to-shoulder with Vajpayee's scramble for the prime ministership.

The decade from 1995 to 2005 was a time when India couldn't quite be sure if it was walking into the free market's promised utopia or religious tribalism's unbridled bloodbath, a worry then (and still) characterised by writer Arundhati Roy as typical for this country that "lived in several centuries at the same



Trial by Fire
Mar. 11, 2002

"Though curfew was imposed in most places and the police turned out in strength, it could not quell the violence. In Ahmedabad's Bapunagar, a township named after Mahatma Gandhi, two groups of over 2,000 each fought one another. Both were armed with swords, sticks and firearms. The casualty count is not known... Amid this, the question being asked most often is: was the attack planned? And if it was, by whom?"